BRUSSELS, BELGIUM

Royal Museums of Fine Arts of Belgium: Masterpieces

Twenty works from the Royal Museums of Fine Arts of Belgium, with attention to how images organise belief, status and surprise.



A gallery full of paintings is a reasonable place to begin a guide to the Royal Museums of Fine Arts of Belgium. In Teniers's picture, however, it is also a display of ownership: the small people stand among an extraordinary quantity of objects. Other works here disturb the habits through which recognisable things are assigned meaning. Magritte repaints a classical cast; Bruegel combines familiar body parts into unfamiliar creatures; an almost invisible fall unsettles a broad landscape.

These twenty works do not tell a simple story of realism giving way to fantasy. The portraits and judicial scenes are constructed presentations too. What changes is how openly each picture exposes the arrangement.

Artline selected these works from documented museum holdings. The selection is independent of the museum, and individual works may be on loan or off display. Dates and attributions retain the qualifications in the linked records.

Explore this selection in Artline

See the selected works alongside books and events from their period, or compare when the artists lived. The books and events provide context, not evidence of direct influence. Works without confirmed dates remain in this guide.

Artworks in context Who lived when?

artlines.org/guides/royal-fine-arts-belgium

The selection · 20

1. Archduke Leopold Wilhelm in His Gallery
   David Teniers the Younger · 1651
2. The Copper Handcuffs
   René Magritte · 1931
3. Dario de Regoyos Playing the Guitar
   Théo van Rysselberghe · 1882
4. Doge Alvise IV Mocenigo Appearing to the People in Saint Mark's
   Francesco Guardi · 1775 - 1777
5. Drunken Silenus with Two Bacchantes
   Anthony van Dyck · 1620
6. Model in Backlight
   Pierre Bonnard · 1908
7. Natural Encounters
   René Magritte · 1945
8. Antoine, the Bastard of Burgundy
   Rogier van der Weyden · 1460
9. Madame Charles Maus
   Théo van Rysselberghe · 1890
10. Johannes Schöner
    Lucas Cranach the Elder · 1529
11. Octave Maus
    Théo van Rysselberghe · 1885
12. The Fall of the Rebel Angels
    Pieter Bruegel the Elder · 1562
13. The Temptation of Saint Anthony
    Salvador Dalí · 1946
14. Yawning Man
    Pieter Bruegel the Elder (attribution uncertain) · Date not established
15. Three Studies of a Lady with a Hat
    Jean-Antoine Watteau · 1715
16. Allegory of Abundance
    Jacob Jordaens · c. 1623
17. The Cook
    Pieter Aertsen · 1559
18. The Depths of Pleasure
    René Magritte · 1948
19. The Justice of Emperor Otto: The Ordeal by Fire
    Dieric Bouts · 1470-1475
20. Landscape with the Fall of Icarus
    Pieter Bruegel the Elder (attribution uncertain) · Date not established

01 / 20

Archduke Leopold Wilhelm in His Gallery

David Teniers the Younger

1651 · Oil on canvas · Royal Museums of Fine Arts of Belgium



David Teniers the Younger. Archduke Leopold Wilhelm of Austria in his Gallery. WikiArt source label: Public domain. Proportional resize and JPEG compression; no crop. Source: https://www.wikiart.org/en/david-teniers-the-younger/archduke-leopold-wilhelm-of-austria-in-his-gallery-1651 · Public domain (WikiArt source label)

Pictures cover the room so thoroughly that looking at one means passing over others. The archduke and his companions become relatively small within this accumulation. Teniers records a way of possessing and displaying art as much as individual paintings: the crowded arrangement makes a collector's abundance itself available to be admired.

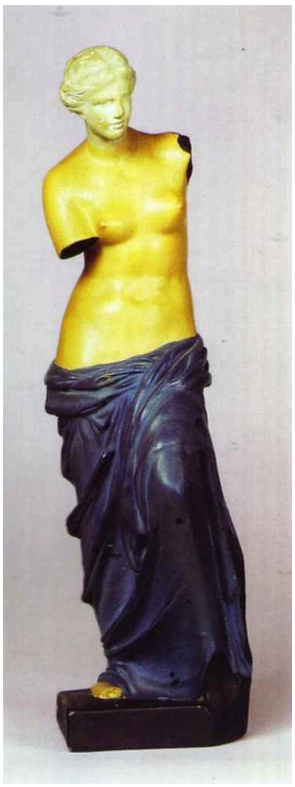
Object source · Open artwork

02 / 20

The Copper Handcuffs

René Magritte

1931 · Oil on plaster · Royal Museums of Fine Arts of Belgium



René Magritte. Copper handcuffs. WikiArt source label: Rene Magritte Fair Use. Proportional resize and JPEG compression; no crop. Source: https://www.wikiart.org/en/rene-magritte/copper-handcuffs-1931 · Rene Magritte Fair Use (WikiArt source label)

Colour divides the cast where its sculptural form would normally remain continuous. The familiar outline of the Venus de Milo survives, but the yellow torso and dark blue drapery establish a new set of boundaries. Magritte's intervention does not depend on concealing the source. Recognition is precisely what allows the imposed divisions to become conspicuous.

Object source · Open artwork

03 / 20

Dario de Regoyos Playing the Guitar

Théo van Rysselberghe

1882 · Oil on panel · Royal Museums of Fine Arts of Belgium



Théo van Rysselberghe. Dario de Regoyos Playing the Guitar. WikiArt source label: Public domain. Proportional resize and JPEG compression; no crop. Source: https://www.wikiart.org/en/theo-van-rysselberghe/dario-de-regoyos-playing-the-guitar-1882 · Public domain (WikiArt source label)

The guitar crosses the sitter's body and gives his arms something to do. Its warmer colour also separates it from the dark clothes, so the activity shapes the portrait both physically and visually. Regoyos is presented through an instrument held in use, rather than through an accessory placed nearby solely to describe his interests.

Object source · Open artwork

04 / 20

Doge Alvise IV Mocenigo Appearing to the People in Saint Mark’s

Francesco Guardi

1775 - 1777 · Oil on canvas · Royal Museums of Fine Arts of Belgium



Francesco Guardi. Doge Alvise IV Mocenigo Appears to the People in St. Mark's Basilica. WikiArt source label: Public domain. Proportional resize and JPEG compression; no crop. Source: https://www.wikiart.org/en/francesco-guardi/doge-alvise-iv-mocenigo-appears-to-the-people-in-st-mark-s-basilica-1777 · Public domain (WikiArt source label)

The ceremony is small in relation to the basilica that contains it. Arches and columns carry the view upward while patches of light keep the architectural mass from becoming immovable. Guardi makes public authority dependent on its setting: the gathering has significance, but the building supplies much of the scale through which that significance is seen.

Object source · Open artwork

05 / 20

Drunken Silenus with Two Bacchantes

Anthony van Dyck

1620 · Royal Museums of Fine Arts of Belgium



Drunken Silenus, supported by two bacchantes. WikiArt; Anthony van Dyck. Proportional resizing and JPEG compression; source frame preserved. · Public domain

Silenus's body has become a weight that other bodies must manage. The figures crowd together because supporting him leaves little room for separation. This physical problem gives the mythological scene its immediate intelligibility. Bent limbs and gathered drapery describe the effort more directly than an explanation of each participant's identity would.

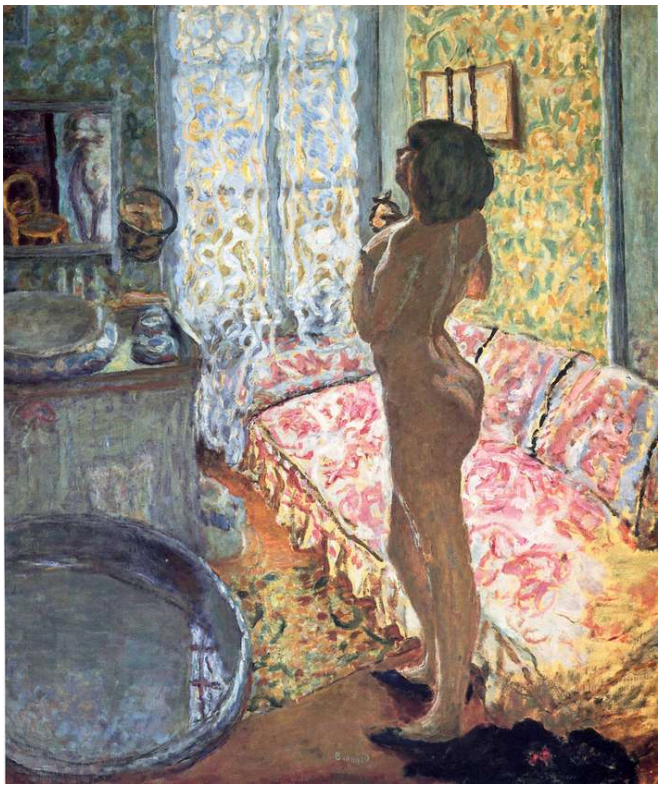
Object source · Open artwork

06 / 20

Model in Backlight

Pierre Bonnard

1908 · Oil on canvas · Royal Museums of Fine Arts of Belgium



Pierre Bonnard. Model in Backlight. WikiArt source label: Public domain. Proportional resize and JPEG compression; no crop. Source: https://www.wikiart.org/en/pierre-bonnard/model-in-backligh-1908 · Public domain (WikiArt source label)

The bright window does not turn the figure into the room's most clearly described object. Pattern, warm interior colour and cooler light compete around the body, making it part of a larger field of surfaces. The picture can be read by following those interruptions rather than treating the room as a passive setting for a nude.

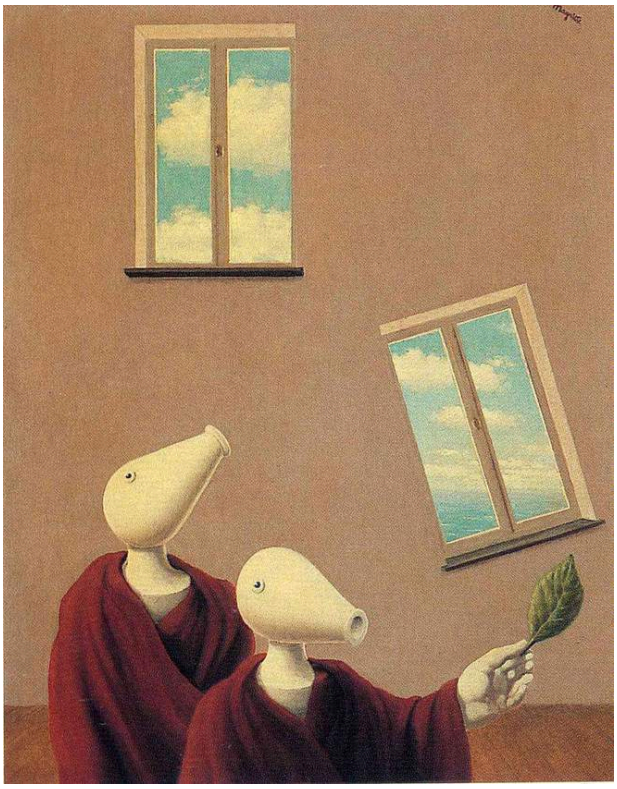
Object source · Open artwork

07 / 20

Natural Encounters

René Magritte

1945 · Oil on canvas · Royal Museums of Fine Arts of Belgium



René Magritte. Natural encounters. WikiArt source label: Rene Magritte Fair Use. Proportional resize and JPEG compression; no crop. Source: https://www.wikiart.org/en/rene-magritte/natural-encounters-1945 · Rene Magritte Fair Use (WikiArt source label)

The encounter is plainly arranged even though its participants are impossible. Red robes give the birdlike beings something like bodily solidity; openings onto sky establish a space around them. The calm separation of forms matters. Strangeness remains available for sustained looking instead of being concealed in darkness or a confused rush of action.

Object source · Open artwork

08 / 20

Antoine, the Bastard of Burgundy

Rogier van der Weyden

1460 · Oil on panel · Royal Museums of Fine Arts of Belgium



Portrait of Antoine, bastard of Burgundy. WikiArt; Rogier van der Weyden. Proportional resizing and JPEG compression; source frame preserved. · Public domain

The arrow occupies the space in front of the sitter, and the gold chain follows his neckline. These objects give the otherwise restrained portrait a public register of status and allegiance. The dark clothes keep their signals distinct. The face remains controlled, offering no narrative that would explain how this formal presentation was received.

Object source · Open artwork

09 / 20

Madame Charles Maus

Théo van Rysselberghe

1890 · Oil on canvas · Royal Museums of Fine Arts of Belgium



Théo van Rysselberghe. Portrait of Madame Charles Maus. WikiArt source label: Public domain. Proportional resize and JPEG compression; no crop. Source: https://www.wikiart.org/en/theo-van-rysselberghe/portrait-of-madame-charles-maus-1890 · Public domain (WikiArt source label)

The dark dress retains a substantial outline while small touches of colour break up the lighter room. Van Rysselberghe allows two kinds of seeing to coexist: the recognition of a seated woman and awareness of the separate marks forming her surroundings. The transition between dress and interior is where their difference becomes easiest to follow.

Object source · Open artwork

10 / 20

Johannes Schöner

Lucas Cranach the Elder

1529 · Oil on wood · Royal Museums of Fine Arts of Belgium



Lucas Cranach the Elder. Portrait of Magdeburg Theologian Dr. Johannes Schöner. WikiArt source label: Public domain. Proportional resize and JPEG compression; no crop. Source: https://www.wikiart.org/en/lucas-cranach-the-elder/portrait-of-magdeburg-theologians-dr-johannes-sch%C3%B6ner-1529 · Public domain (WikiArt source label)

Hair, fur and the red garment crowd close to the sitter's head, supplying several kinds of texture within a compact portrait. The hands remain together below. With little architectural setting to describe him, the figure's authority rests on this tightly organised presentation rather than on a surrounding office, landscape or collection of possessions.

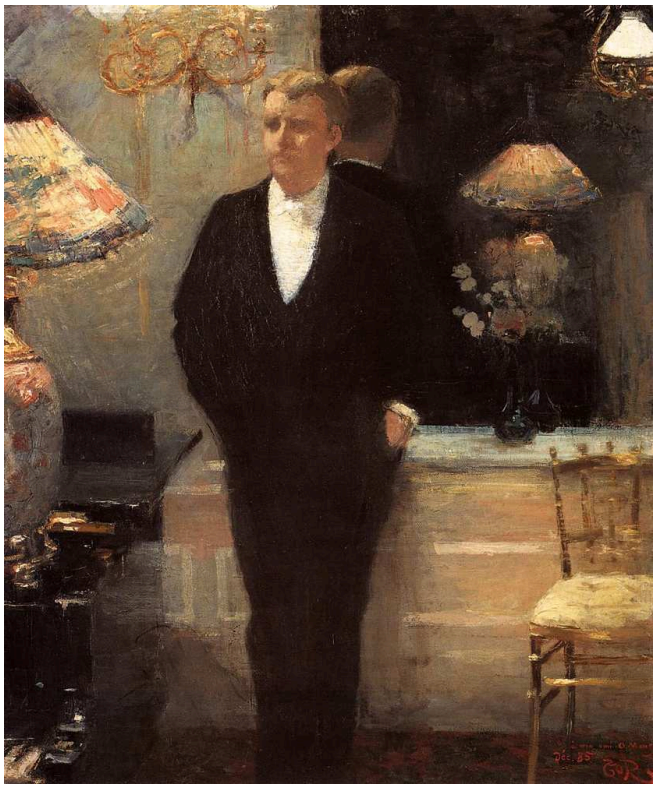
Object source · Open artwork

11 / 20

Octave Maus

Théo van Rysselberghe

1885 · Oil on canvas · Royal Museums of Fine Arts of Belgium



Théo van Rysselberghe. Portrait of Octave Maus. WikiArt source label: Public domain. Proportional resize and JPEG compression; no crop. Source: https://www.wikiart.org/en/theo-van-rysselberghe/portrait-of-octave-maus-1885 · Public domain (WikiArt source label)

The full-length format gives the sitter's bearing as much work to do as his facial likeness. His dark silhouette holds its shape against flowers and furnishings whose outlines are softer. Compare this with the later portrait of Madame Charles Maus: Van Rysselberghe changes the treatment of the room without abandoning the distinction between figure and setting.

Object source · Open artwork

12 / 20

The Fall of the Rebel Angels

Pieter Bruegel the Elder

1562 · Oil on panel · Royal Museums of Fine Arts of Belgium



Pieter Bruegel the Elder. The Fall of the Rebel Angels. WikiArt source label: Public domain. Proportional resize and JPEG compression; no crop. Source: https://www.wikiart.org/en/pieter-bruegel-the-elder/the-fall-of-the-rebel-angels-1562 · Public domain (WikiArt source label)

The upper figure can be recognised relatively quickly; the lower mass takes longer to separate into creatures. Familiar wings, shells and limbs join bodies that do not behave like familiar animals. That change in legibility gives the fall a pictorial form: order is progressively lost as attention enters the dense, hybrid crowd.

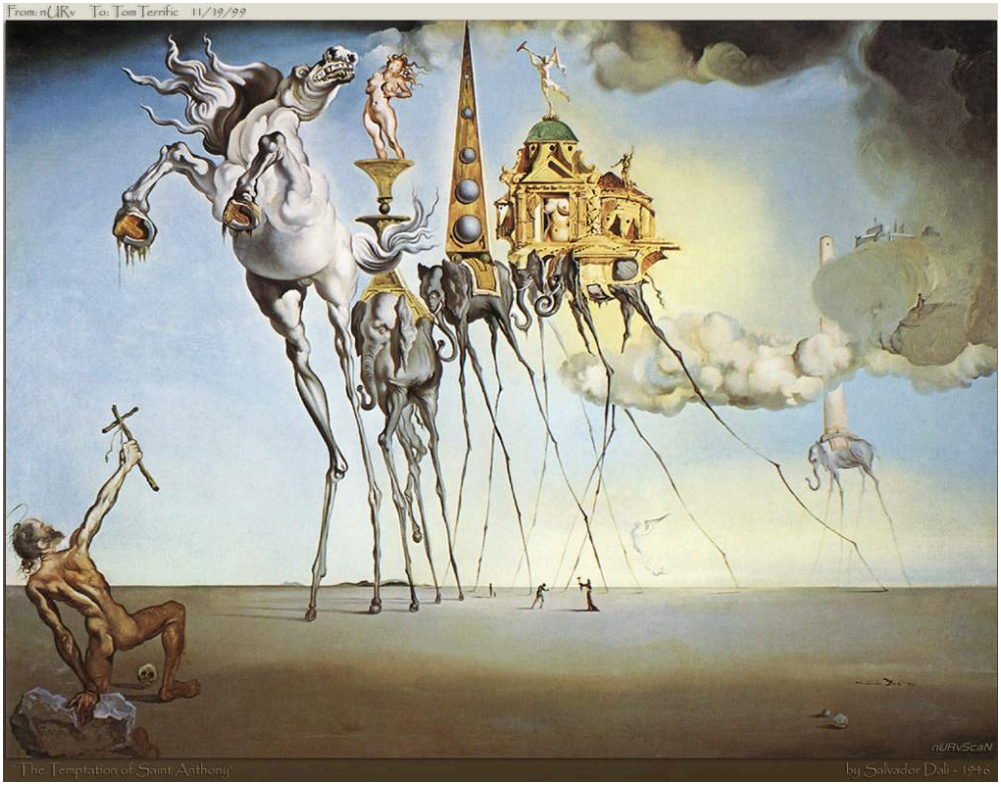
Object source · Open artwork

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The Temptation of Saint Anthony

Salvador Dalí

1946 · Oil on canvas · Royal Museums of Fine Arts of Belgium



Salvador Dalí. The Temptation of St. Anthony. WikiArt source label: Salvador Dali Fair Use. Proportional resize and JPEG compression; no crop. Source: https://www.wikiart.org/en/salvador-dali/the-temptation-of-st-anthony · Salvador Dali Fair Use (WikiArt source label)

The animals appear heavy enough to carry architecture, yet their extremely thin legs offer implausible support. The kneeling saint's raised cross confronts a procession whose scale is difficult to measure. Dalí keeps the objects clearly described while breaking the ordinary relations between weight, size and balance that would make them physically possible.

Object source · Open artwork

14 / 20

Yawning Man

Pieter Bruegel the Elder (attribution uncertain)

Date not established · Oil on panel · Royal Museums of Fine Arts of Belgium



Pieter Bruegel the Elder. Yawning Man (disputed attribution). WikiArt source label: Public domain. Proportional resize and JPEG compression; no crop. Source: https://www.wikiart.org/en/pieter-bruegel-the-elder/yawning-man-disputed-attribution-1563 · Public domain (WikiArt source label)

A yawn temporarily reorganises the whole face: the mouth opens, the eyes close and the upper lip rises. It is an action poorly suited to a dignified formal likeness, which makes its isolation here especially pointed. The work's uncertain attribution should remain visible; the specificity of the expression does not resolve who painted it.

Object source · Open artwork

15 / 20

Three Studies of a Lady with a Hat

Jean-Antoine Watteau

1715 · Chalk on paper · Royal Museums of Fine Arts of Belgium



Three Studies of a Lady with a Hat. WikiArt; Jean-Antoine Watteau. Proportional resizing and JPEG compression; source frame preserved. · Public domain

The same hat-wearing figure appears at different angles, allowing the poses to be compared without pretending they occurred simultaneously in one room. Bare areas keep the studies apart. The sheet preserves alternatives, showing how clothing changes its shape when a body turns and how much a finished pose leaves outside its final arrangement.

Object source · Open artwork

16 / 20

Allegory of Abundance

Jacob Jordaens

c. 1623 · Royal Museums of Fine Arts of Belgium



Jacob Jordaens. Allegory of Abundance. WikiArt source label: Public domain. Proportional resize and JPEG compression; no crop. Source: https://www.wikiart.org/en/jacob-jordaens/allegory-of-abundance · Public domain (WikiArt source label)

Fruit, children and overlapping bodies fill the space so densely that abundance becomes a condition of the composition. The turning female figure is part of that accumulation, rather than a detached symbol above it. Repeated rounded shapes connect living bodies and produce, giving the allegorical subject an emphatically material form.

Object source · Open artwork

17 / 20

The Cook

Pieter Aertsen

1559 · Royal Museums of Fine Arts of Belgium



Pieter Aertsen. Cook in front of the Stove. Image: WikiArt. Public domain (WikiArt label). Proportionally resized and JPEG compressed; no crop. · Public domain (WikiArt label)

The cook meets the viewer's attention while meat, vegetables and vessels occupy a substantial foreground. These things describe the work around her, but her scale and outward gaze prevent the picture from becoming simply an arrangement of provisions. Kitchen labour is presented through a figure able to hold the image as firmly as its plentiful objects.

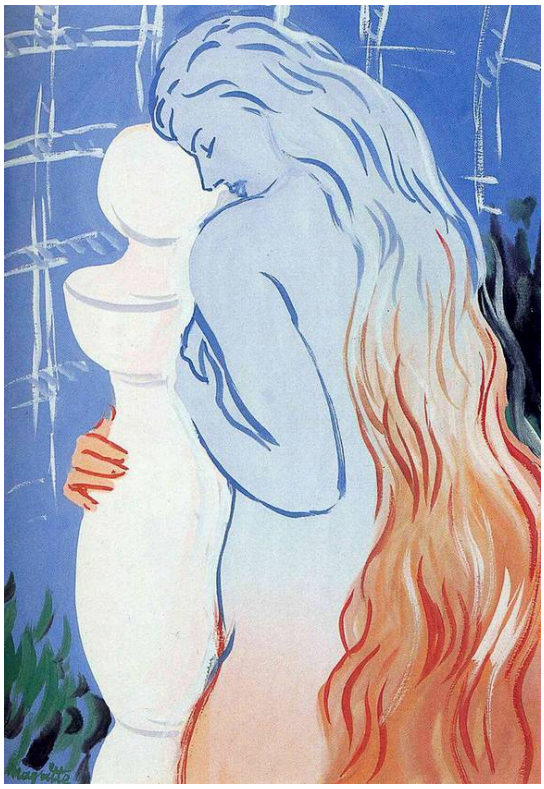
Object source · Open artwork

18 / 20

The Depths of Pleasure

René Magritte

1948 · Royal Museums of Fine Arts of Belgium



René Magritte. Depths of pleasure. WikiArt source label: Rene Magritte Fair Use. Proportional resize and JPEG compression; no crop. Source: https://www.wikiart.org/en/rene-magritte/depths-of-pleasure-1948 · Rene Magritte Fair Use (WikiArt source label)

Loose outlines and rough areas of red, orange and blue differ from the smooth clarity associated with many of Magritte's other paintings. The female form remains recognisable without settling into a continuous surface. Seen beside *Natural Encounters*, this work prevents a single finish or manner from standing in for the artist's whole practice.

Object source · Open artwork

19 / 20

The Justice of Emperor Otto: The Ordeal by Fire

Dieric Bouts

1470-1475 · Royal Museums of Fine Arts of Belgium



Dieric Bouts. Justice of the Emperor Otto: The Ordeal by Fire. Image: WikiArt. Public domain (WikiArt label). Proportionally resized and JPEG compressed; no crop. · Public domain (WikiArt label)

The tiled hall and upright witnesses give the ordeal an appearance of measured procedure. Yet the test concerns bodily danger, not merely a formal exchange of words. The tension lies between that regulated setting and the means by which a claim is judged. Bouts makes the audience's presence an essential part of the event.

Object source · Open artwork

20 / 20

Landscape with the Fall of Icarus

Pieter Bruegel the Elder (attribution uncertain)

Date not established · Royal Museums of Fine Arts of Belgium



Pieter Bruegel the Elder. Landscape with the Fall of Icarus. Image: WikiArt. Public domain (WikiArt label). Proportionally resized and JPEG compressed; no crop. · Public domain (WikiArt label)

The ploughman and ships make the landscape readily readable before the small legs in the water interrupt it. Knowing the title changes the hierarchy: an easily missed incident becomes the named subject. Attribution and dating remain unresolved. The museum announced new technical research in 2026, so the painting should not be presented as an unquestioned Bruegel original.

Object source · Open artwork

Separate a collection from a route

These works belong to a museum organisation with different collections and display arrangements. Check the relevant museum and individual work before visiting. In Artline, comparing dates can clarify how far apart these experiments were made; resemblance alone does not establish that one artist knew another's work.

Further reading

Bruegel: Unseen Masterpieces

Royal Museums of Fine Arts of Belgium · Read or download the museum booklet · English

The museum’s illustrated booklet opens up details in its Bruegel collection. Read its older attribution language alongside the current research notice for The Fall of Icarus, whose authorship remains under investigation.

Museum website · Official collection guide

Sources and visitor information checked: 2026-10-12

Artline · Royal Museums of Fine Arts of Belgium: Masterpieces